CS 250

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Sprint Review and Retrospective: SNHU Travel Project

## Applying Roles

In the transition of ChadaTech to an Agile methodology, the success of the SNHU Travel project really depended on how each person handled their specific role. As the Scrum Master, my job was to facilitate the process and remove obstacles, but the specific work from my teammates is what drove us forward.

Our Product Owner acted as the bridge between the business vision and the developers. Her main contribution was taking the raw feedback from the focus groups, where customers mentioned wanting things like "budget limits" or "top destinations" and turning them into a prioritized Product Backlog. By making the "Top Five Destination List" her highest priority, she ensured that we were working on the most valuable items first, which helped expand the client base.

On the development side, the Developer and Brian had to work very closely. The Developer focused on producing just enough design so we could stay flexible and iterate. Our Testers role was huge for clearing up any ambiguity. For example, he didn’t just wait for code to be finished but he also reached out to the Product Owner early to ask if the "Top 10" list should count down from 10 or start at 1. This prevented the Developer from wasting time writing code that didn't match what the client actually wanted.

## Completing User Stories

Using a Scrum-Agile approach changed the SDLC from a long, rigid process into something focused on outcomes. In Waterfall, we would have spent the whole five weeks just doing documentation. With Agile, user stories helped us understand the "Why" behind every task.

For instance, a User Story #4 (Budget Based Search Filter) was successful because it was written in plain English: "As an end user, I want to set a price limit... so that I can find travel packages that fit my budget." This allowed the team to find the best technical solution during the sprint. Because the story included clear Acceptance Criteria, like the results refreshing instantly, the tester was able to create functional test cases (TC-04) that checked for specific behaviors, ensuring the feature actually worked for the traveler.

## Handling Interruptions

The biggest challenge for the SNHU Travel project was the tight five-week deadline. In our old Waterfall model, a short timeline with vague requirements usually leads to a lot of stress and a product that doesn't work. Agile supported us by allowing the team to pivot when things changed.

When we realized that the "Mobile App" requirement (User Story #3) was actually an "Epic" that was too big for one sprint, we didn't just ignore it. We used the Daily Scrum to identify this roadblock immediately. By talking about it, we were able to break it down into smaller components and reprioritize the backlog. This allowed us to shift lower-priority items out of the current sprint so we could stay focused on the essential functionality needed for the vacation planning season.

## Communication

Effective communication was the heartbeat of this project. We moved away from long status reports and used practices that created openness and transparency. One example was the email sent from the Developer to the Product Owner and Tester asking for clarification on User Story #102. The Developer asked: *"I need the Product Owner to confirm if the table view should collapse into a list view or simply shrink on mobile devices."*

This was effective because it was specific and reduced the "wait time" of long email chains. We also used Information Radiators like our Scrum Board. By displaying the status of tasks (To Do, In Progress, Done) publicly, everyone including our client, had an honest view of our progress without having to interrupt the developers. This created trust and made sure there were no surprises during the Sprint Review.

## Organizational Tools

The main tool that helped our efficiency was a digital Product Backlog (like JIRA). While Scrum events tell us *when* to talk, tools like JIRA define *how* work is tracked. It was much more effective than email because we could link test cases directly to user stories and document technical roadblocks in one place.

This tool worked alongside our Scrum Events:

- Daily Scrums: These were essential for transparency, allowing us to sync our work and identify impediments in real time.
- Backlog Refinement: This helped reduce ambiguity in the user stories, which allowed our Developer and Tester to work much faster.

- Sprint Reviews: Having the client inspect the booking system allowed us to get frequent feedback so we didn't spend sprints building features that users found unnecessary.

## Evaluating Agile Process

The Scrum-Agile approach was definitely the right move for the SNHU Travel project.

- Pros: The main benefit was agility and value maximization. We were able to produce enough design to remain flexible and iterate based on the cleints feedback. It also kept the team from feeling overwhelmed by the five-week deadline since we focused on one increment at a time.
- Cons: It does require a lot of constant collaboration and peer reviews to keep the quality high, which can be a big shift for a team used to working in silos. It also requires the Product Owner to be very active in clarifying roles and priorities.

## Conclusion

Overall, the Scrum-Agile approach was the best way to handle the SNHU Travel project. Because the travel industry changes fast and our deadline was so short, we needed a process that allowed for frequent feedback and realistic planning. Transitioning all of ChadaTech to this methodology will help us deliver higher value products and build a more cohesive culture where everyone is aligned on the same goals.

## Citations

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